NEPQ Phase 3 — Problem Awareness

Cheat sheet · 5 Nov 2026

Purpose

Help the prospect find and name their **real problem** themselves: what it is, how long it has lasted, what causes it, and what it is costing them. You guide; they diagnose.

Do / Don't

Do	Don't
Start positive ("What do you like about it?")	Attack their current strategy
Ask neutral, open questions	Tell them what their problem is
Drill into vague answers ("What do you mean by…?")	Accept "it's fine" or "I wish it was faster" at face value
Be patient and reflect their words back	Rush to your solution

The question flow

Step	Example question
1. Open the door	"Is there anything you'd change about how you're doing it?"
2. Clarify	"What do you mean by faster / more consistent?"
3. Duration	"How long has that been a problem?"
4. Cause	"What do you think is causing that?"
5. Impact	"How has that affected your motivation / results / business?"

Why it works: people defend what you criticise, but they believe what they say themselves. If they spot the gap in their own words, the case for change is theirs, and your solution later feels like help, not a pitch.

Applied to TRB: open pain discovery with gym owners

Leave the product out of the conversation. Don't mention reviews, Google or marketing. Find out what really keeps them up at night, then decide later whether you can solve it.

Step	Neutral version
Open the door	"If you could wave a magic wand and fix one thing in the business, what would it be?"
Clarify	"When you say that, what does it actually look like day to day?"
Duration	"How long has that been going on?"
Cause	"What do you think is behind it?"
Impact	"What is that costing you? Money, members, time, your own energy?"
Tried before	"What have you already tried to fix it? How did that go?"

Common themes to listen for (don't suggest them): getting new members, keeping members (churn), staff and coaches, admin and payments, time and burnout, cash flow, standing out from big chains.

Rules: log their exact words in the CRM Pains tab. Count which pain comes up most across your 20 conversations. Only then decide what to build or pitch. If reviews never come up, that is useful data, not a failure.

Self-check after each call

☐ Did I keep my product out of it?

☐ Did they name the problem in their own words?

☐ Do I know how long it has lasted, and why?

☐ Do I know what it is costing them (members, money, motivation)?

☐ Did I drill into every vague answer?

☐ Did I avoid pitching too early?

Next phase: Solution Awareness, where the prospect pictures what life looks like with the problem solved.